

THEORY NOTEBOOK

Critical Notes on the Canon:

*What the Classic Models Get Right, What They Miss, and What the Platform
Transition Broke*

**MSJ2201: Mass Communication
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A Note on Method

These notes work through five theoretical frameworks from the mass communication canon: agenda-setting, framing, uses and gratifications, the spiral of silence, and the network/platform society tradition. The approach is not exegetical. I am less interested in summarising what the theories say than in testing where they hold and where they break under the conditions of algorithmically mediated communication. That is the question this course kept returning me to: these models were built for broadcast-era media systems. Which parts survive the platform transition? Which require revision? Which should probably be retired?

The notes are organised by framework. Within each, I try to identify the durable theoretical contribution, the assumptions that were always contestable, and the specific ways the platform environment strains or breaks the model. The frameworks are not treated symmetrically — some warrant more attention than others, and the depth of each section reflects where the theoretical problems seem most interesting or most unresolved.

I. Agenda-Setting Theory (McCombs & Shaw, 1972)

McCombs and Shaw's study of the 1968 US presidential election established a correlation between the issues the press covered prominently and the issues voters ranked as most important. The media, on this account, do not tell people what to think; they tell people what to think about. Salience transfer — the movement of issue importance from the media agenda to the public agenda — is the core mechanism. Second-level agenda-setting, developed through subsequent research, extends the claim to attributes: not only which issues receive coverage but which aspects of those issues are emphasised shapes how the public conceives of them (McCombs, 2004).

The first-level claim has held up remarkably well across different national contexts and methodological approaches. The correlation between coverage intensity and perceived issue salience is one of the most replicated findings in mass communication research. Attribute agenda-setting is more contested — the mechanisms are less clearly specified and the effect sizes in experimental studies are smaller — but the basic logic is coherent and the evidence base is substantial.

The platform transition does not invalidate agenda-setting. If anything, it intensifies the salience question. Algorithmic feeds are, in structural terms, salience machines: they continuously select from available content and determine what reaches each user's attention. But the transition does break three of the theory's foundational assumptions.

The first is the assumption of a unified agenda. Broadcast-era agenda-setting presupposed a concentrated gatekeeping system — a small number of outlets with shared professional norms producing a roughly shared public agenda. That system is gone, or at minimum severely disrupted. Different users inhabiting different algorithmic information environments may now be exposed to structurally different agendas. The question is no longer “what agenda does the media set?” but “whose agenda gets set for which segment of the public, through which algorithmic pathway, with what differential consequences for shared political discourse?” The original model has no apparatus for answering this.

The second is directionality. The original model is unidirectional: media institutions set the agenda; the public follows. Platform environments have complicated this considerably. Algorithmic systems respond to engagement signals — they amplify what users respond to. This creates feedback loops in which public attention can drive media coverage as readily as the reverse. The mechanism of salience formation is now bidirectional at minimum, and quite possibly cyclical in ways that require new modelling.

The third is speed. The theory was built on studies tracking coverage and opinion over weeks or months. Salience in platform environments can shift in hours. Whether the psychological and social mechanisms of agenda-setting operate on that timescale is an open empirical question. The original studies cannot answer it.

The core insight survives. The original mechanism does not transfer cleanly. Agenda-setting in the platform era needs a multi-agent, multi-directional model that specifies how algorithmic curation interacts with journalistic production, user behaviour, and political actors — not a single pipeline from media institutions to public opinion.

II. Framing Theory (Goffman, 1974; Entman, 1993)

Framing theory has two distinct intellectual origins that are sometimes conflated in media research. Goffman's (1974) original sociological concept referred to the interpretive schemas people use to make sense of experience — frames as mental structures, not textual properties. Entman's (1993) media-focused reformulation operationalised framing as a property of texts: the selection and salience of particular aspects of a perceived reality to promote a specific problem definition, causal interpretation, moral evaluation, or treatment recommendation. Most subsequent media framing research works in Entman's tradition.

The experimental evidence for framing effects is substantial. Iyengar's (1991) studies of episodic versus thematic television news framing are a particularly clean demonstration: the same social issue (poverty, crime, unemployment) framed as an individual case produced attributions of individual responsibility; framed as a systemic pattern, it produced attributions of social responsibility. The consequences for policy preferences were significant. This is the kind of finding that travels well — the underlying mechanism (contextual emphasis shapes interpretation) is robust and replicable.

The Algorithmic Framing Problem

The most interesting theoretical challenge framing theory faces in the platform era is one that has received less attention than it deserves. The dominant tradition treats frames as the property of producers: journalists select frames, politicians deploy them,

advocacy groups contest them. The platform environment introduces a new framing agent — the algorithm — that does not produce content but curates context. And context, for framing purposes, is not incidental. It is constitutive.

Consider what it means for an image to appear in a user's feed flanked by posts from community members who share a particular political orientation versus appearing between news items from outlets with a different political tendency. The image's "frame" in the textual sense — its caption, its headline, its editorial framing — may be identical in both cases. The interpretive context in which it is encountered is not. The algorithm that curates that context is performing something that functions as a framing operation, without producing any frame-bearing text itself.

Existing framing research has no adequate account of this. The unit of analysis in most content-analytic framing research is the discrete text: the article, the broadcast segment, the post. That unit is theoretically coherent when texts are encountered in relatively stable contexts — on the front page of a newspaper, in a broadcast news programme. It is less coherent when the "text" is embedded in an algorithmically assembled stream that is unique to each user and changes continuously. Framing theory needs either to expand its unit of analysis from the discrete text to the assembled feed, or to develop a distinct account of algorithmic framing as a second-order process operating on top of first-order textual frames.

The core experimental findings on framing effects are well-established and travel to new media contexts reasonably well. The theory's account of who does the framing is where the work needs to be done. Platform algorithms are framing agents of the first order. The existing literature has not caught up with this.

III. Uses and Gratifications (Katz, Blumler & Gurevitch, 1974)

Uses and gratifications theory inverts the standard effects question. Instead of asking what media do to audiences, it asks what audiences do with media. Katz, Blumler and Gurevitch (1974) proposed that media use is purposive: people select media and content to satisfy particular needs, whether informational, entertainment-seeking, social,

identity-related, or escapist. The research agenda is to map the relationship between gratifications sought, media use patterns, and gratifications obtained.

The theoretical shift this represented was significant and necessary. The strong effects tradition that dominated early mass communication research — the hypodermic needle model, stimulus-response thinking — treated audiences as passive recipients of media influence, which was empirically unsupportable. The evidence that media use is purposive and that audiences bring active interpretive frameworks to content is well established. This part of the theory holds.

The Constrained Choice Problem

What uses and gratifications assumed, and what the platform environment has strained, is the scope of audience agency. The theory imagines an audience that selects from available media to satisfy pre-existing needs. This is a plausible model when the choice environment is relatively open — when the user selects a newspaper, a television channel, a genre of content. It is a more questionable model when the choice environment is algorithmically constructed.

The user who “chooses” to read a particular story on Facebook or watch a particular video on YouTube has, in many cases, selected from a menu curated by an algorithm designed to maximise engagement — not to satisfy the user’s stated informational needs. The gratification sought and the gratification supplied by the platform’s logic may not be the same thing. A user seeking political information may be supplied with politically charged entertainment content that produces arousal without information — because the algorithm’s objective function rewards engagement, not need-satisfaction.

This is not a trivial qualification. If the choice set from which users select is itself engineered to produce particular patterns of engagement, the relationship between need, selection, and gratification that the theory proposes is systematically distorted. The theory’s account of media use needs to incorporate the structural constraints on agency that platform architectures impose, rather than treating selection as relatively unconstrained.

A second problem is the individualism of the framework. Gratification-seeking is modelled as an individual process. But media use patterns, aggregated across millions of users in algorithmic environments, produce structural information exposure patterns — differential distributions of content across population segments — that have collective consequences regardless of individual intentions. The theory has little apparatus for connecting individual-level gratification-seeking to aggregate structural effects.

Uses and gratifications identified something real: media use is purposive and audiences are active. The theory's limitation is that it models agency without adequately accounting for the structural conditions within which agency operates. In platform environments, those conditions are designed, commercially motivated, and largely opaque to users.

IV. The Spiral of Silence (Noelle-Neumann, 1974)

The spiral of silence is the most counterintuitive of the classic models and, I think, the one whose platform-era implications are most underexplored. Noelle-Neumann's (1974) claim is that people monitor their environment for the distribution of opinion on contested issues, and that when they perceive their own view to be in the minority or losing ground, they become less willing to express it publicly — to avoid social isolation. The result is a spiral: the perceived minority view is expressed less, which makes it appear more marginal, which suppresses expression further.

Two features of the theory are worth holding onto. First, the distinction between private opinion and expressed opinion is empirically important and frequently ignored in public opinion research that treats survey responses as direct measures of opinion. The conditions under which people express views publicly may systematically diverge from the conditions under which they hold them privately. Second, the claim that perceived opinion distribution — not actual opinion distribution — shapes willingness to speak means that media representations of the opinion climate can influence expression even when they are inaccurate. This is not a trivial mechanism.

Fragmentation and the Counter-Spiral

The theory was formulated assuming a relatively unified opinion environment in which media provide consistent signals about what the majority believes. In a fragmented, algorithmically curated information environment, this assumption fails in an interesting way. Different users receive different signals about which views are socially dominant. A view that appears to be a confident majority position within one algorithmic community may appear marginal within another. The result could theoretically be multiple simultaneous spirals, running in different directions, within different audience segments — a situation the original model has no apparatus to describe.

There is also a counter-mechanism that Noelle-Neumann did not anticipate and that platform environments have made visible. Online communities can allow geographically or socially isolated individuals holding minority views to discover that they are not, in fact, as isolated as they believed. This discovery can produce what some researchers have called a “spiral of voice” — the online visibility of a previously silenced community encouraging further expression rather than suppressing it (Hampton et al., 2014). Whether this is a genuine counter-mechanism or a temporary disruption that eventually resolves into new spirals is an open question.

The costs of expressing minority opinions have also changed structurally. Noelle-Neumann’s primary feared consequence was social isolation in face-to-face community contexts. Online expression carries different risks: targeted harassment, coordinated pile-ons, reputational damage via searchable permanent record. These are not simply scaled-up versions of the social isolation Noelle-Neumann described. They are different in kind, and a theory of silence in platform environments needs to account for them specifically.

The distinction between private opinion and expressed opinion, and the role of perceived opinion climate in shaping expression, are genuine and durable insights. The specific mechanism Noelle-Neumann described — the unified spiral in a mass media environment — is probably not how opinion dynamics work in fragmented algorithmic environments. This is one of the theories most in need of systematic platform-era revision.

V. Network Society to Platform Society (Castells, 1996; van Dijck, Poell & de Waal, 2018)

Castells' network society thesis is less a communication theory than a political economy of information capitalism, but its implications for communication are substantial. The argument is that the shift from industrial to informational capitalism reorganises social structure around networks rather than hierarchies, and that power in network societies operates through control over network infrastructure — who can connect to whom, who is included and excluded, and who controls the switching points between networks (Castells, 1996). Communication networks, on this account, are not neutral channels; they are structures of power.

Van Dijck, Poell and de Waal's (2018) concept of "platformisation" specifies and updates this for the contemporary moment. Platforms, they argue, are not merely technical intermediaries. They actively restructure the social, civic, and commercial institutions they touch around their own operational logic — datafication (the rendering of social activity as quantifiable data), commodification (the extraction of value from that data), and selection (algorithmic filtering that determines what is visible and to whom). Platformisation is the process by which this logic colonises domains of social life that previously operated by different norms.

What This Framework Offers That the Others Do Not

The network/platform society tradition is theoretically mature in a way the classic effects models are not. It does not ask about the effects of particular messages on particular audiences. It asks about the structural conditions that determine who can communicate with whom, on what terms, with what access to visibility and reach. This is the right level of analysis for understanding platform power. The question of whether a particular news frame shifted a particular attitude is a second-order question. The first-order question is: who controls the infrastructure through which any frame reaches any audience?

Van Dijck et al.'s (2018) account of platformisation is also the most useful theoretical tool currently available for analysing the relationship between platform logic and journalism. The argument is not that platforms have bad intentions toward journalism, or that individual platform decisions are harmful. It is that journalism — as an institution — is being restructured around platform operational logic, and that this restructuring has consequences for what journalism is, what it can do, and whose interests it serves. That is a structural argument, and it is more analytically powerful than the frame-by-frame or story-by-story analysis that most platform journalism research conducts.

The Global South Gap

The most significant limitation of the platform society framework is its geographic parochialism. Castells drew primarily on North American and Western European material. Van Dijck et al.'s empirical work is similarly weighted toward the Netherlands, the United States, and Western Europe. Platformisation as a concept was developed in contexts where pre-existing institutional structures — public service broadcasting, regulatory frameworks, professional journalism norms — were relatively robust before platforms arrived. The dynamics of platformisation in contexts where those institutional structures were weaker or absent, or where they were shaped by different political histories, are likely to be significantly different.

Bangladesh is a useful case in point. The platformisation of Bangladeshi news media has occurred in a context of weak press freedom protections, an underdeveloped tradition of commercially independent journalism, and platform governance conducted entirely outside the country by companies with limited accountability to Bangladeshi users, regulatory bodies, or democratic norms. The consequences are not simply the Western pattern of disruption accelerated. They involve different power dynamics, different vulnerabilities, and different stakes. A genuinely global theory of platformisation needs to build those differences into its analytical framework rather than treating the Global South as a delayed version of Western trajectories.

The platform society framework is the most analytically powerful of the five covered here for understanding contemporary communication systems. Its limitation is empirical scope, not theoretical structure. Extending it seriously to Global South contexts is, in my view, the most productive frontier in this area of the literature.

Conclusion: Which Questions Still Matter

Reading these theories against the platform era, I keep arriving at the same observation from different directions. The classic models are not simply wrong. They asked the right questions for their moment, and many of their empirical findings are robust enough to be worth building on. What they assumed — unified media systems, broadcast-era information flows, audiences whose agency was constrained mainly by habit and availability rather than by algorithmic architecture — those assumptions need to go.

The most theoretically productive move, I think, is not to abandon the effects tradition in favour of structural analysis, or vice versa. It is to insist that structural analysis and effects research answer to each other. Understanding how platform algorithms curate context (a structural question) matters because context shapes interpretation (an effects question that framing theory helps us analyse). Understanding how perceived opinion climate shapes expression (the spiral of silence) matters differently when the opinion climate is algorithmically curated for each user rather than broadcast uniformly to a mass audience.

The gap that remains largest, from where I sit, is the Global South. Most of the theoretical apparatus in mass communication — the classic models and their platform-era revisions alike — was built in and for Western European and North American media systems. The conditions under which platformisation is occurring in Bangladesh, the specific vulnerabilities it creates, and the specific forms of resilience or resistance it encounters, are not well served by theories that treat those conditions as a trailing version of what happened in New York or Amsterdam. That is the work that needs doing, and it is not being done at anywhere near the pace the situation demands.

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